

LINCOLN BEACHEY

IN THE PERIOD BEFORE WORLD WAR I, stunt flying turned California pilot Lincoln Beachey (1887–1915) into one of the most famous personalities in the United States. Beachey originally made his name piloting experimental airships, before graduating to airplanes in 1910.

Taken on by Curtiss to create publicity for his



AMERICAN DAREDEVIL

Lincoln Beachey is shown here seated at the controls of his specially modified Curtiss Beachey Special. His breathtaking stunts drew crowds in their hundreds of thousands.

aircraft, Beachey proved both a great showman and a masterly aviator with an iron nerve. He was the first American flier to loop the loop and briefly held the world altitude record in 1911 – the same year in which he performed one of his most famous feats of bravado, by flying across Niagara Falls. A series of staged races with champion automobile driver Barney Oldfield in 1914 was especially popular with the public.

Although a daredevil by nature, Beachey's shows were always based on meticulous technical preparation. However, in March 1915, his machine let him down and he crashed into the sea off San Francisco. He was just 28 years old when he died.

was an impressive sign of progress that, for example, in the Circuit-of-Europe race, a whole fleet of aircraft crossed the Channel twice without incident. But flying was still only viable in good weather. Wind and fog were especially dangerous, while in a rain shower pilots were soaked, and in the cold they froze. The high number of minor crashes and engine failures meant that any long-distance flight required a vast support system on the ground – hence the accompanying steam train or cavalcade of cars – to supply spare parts and technical assistance at frequent intervals.

Cal Rodgers' spectacularly accident-prone flight across the United States in the *Vin Fiz* was only an extreme example of a common phenomenon. When French aviator Roland Garros contested the 1911 Paris-to-Rome race, he

set off in one Blériot monoplane, wrecked it in the south of France, bought another off a local aviation enthusiast, wrecked that in Italy, and had to have a third machine sent to him from Paris by express train to finish the course. Even in decent weather, with good visibility, fliers had serious trouble finding their way from place to place. Most followed roads or railroad lines – railroad stations were especially useful, because a disoriented pilot could swoop down and read the name of the town.

“An airplane in the hands of Lincoln Beachey is poetry. His mastery is a thing of beauty to watch. He is the most wonderful flier of all.”

ORVILLE WRIGHT

Some pilots were prepared to navigate across country by map and compass, but they often got hopelessly lost. As a last resort, a pilot could land his airplane in a field and ask some rural worker to tell him the way.

Sporting entertainment

One of the most impressive of all early aviation feats, Roland Garros' nonstop flight across the Mediterranean from Fréjus (Provence) to Bizerte (Tunisia) took place in 1913 – known to the French as the “glorious year” of aviation. But by then, the public had begun to grow accustomed to the miracle of flight. Flying displays and tournaments had quickly turned into a routine form of sporting entertainment. Teams of professional aviators toured internationally, putting on shows, while pilots mounted patchy displays on almost any weekend when the weather was tolerable, in aerodromes based in the suburbs of most major European cities.

Future aircraft manufacturer Anthony Fokker has left a fascinating description of his life as a young pilot based at the Johannisthal airfield, outside Berlin, in 1912. On Saturday and Sunday afternoons a substantial crowd would gather, paying a small entrance fee to watch the aviators perform. The local pilots divided the gate money between themselves in proportion to the amount of time each had spent in the air. This meant that any flier who was prepared to risk taking his machine up in bad

weather, when the rest stayed grounded, could make good money. The pilots were a raffish lot. As Fokker writes, “sober, industrious pilots and designers



AERIAL ACROBATICS

Young French pilot Adolphe Pegoud – the first to perform “loop-the-loops” as part of his aerobatic display – is shown here mid-maneuver in a Blériot XI above a crowded airfield near Vienna. The first-ever loop was completed by a Russian pilot, Lt. Pyotr Nesterov, in August 1913. Expecting a rousing welcome for this daring feat, he was instead arrested for endangering government property.